Gandhi's methods of non-violent protest influenced generations of freedom fighters and activists all over the world. US civil rights activist Martin Luther King Jr, South African anti-apartheid activist (and later president) Nelson Mandela, as well as the Dalai Lama, the exiled Tibetan spiritual leader, all count him among their influences.

Death and legacy

In 1947, British India was partitioned into India and Pakistan. This forced many thousands of Hindus, Muslims and Sikhs to leave their homes to make new lives far away. It also led to tremendous communal violence in which many thousands died. A horrified Gandhi, now in his seventies, travelled across the country pleading with people to lay down their arms and stop fighting. Although revered by millions, there were some who disagreed with Gandhi's ideas and disapproved of his methods. For instance, some Muslims, including Mohammed Ali Jinnah, believed that Gandhi put the interests of Hindus first, while Hindu nationalists believed Gandhi had more sympathy for Muslims than for Hindus. This latter belief was to prove deadly: On 30 January 1948, a Hindu nationalist named Nathuram Godse assassinated Gandhi in New Delhi. His death so soon after the achievement of independence was mourned by millions, both in India and in the world at large. Today, Gandhi's beliefs and legacy are questioned by some. But, despite his flaws, there can be no doubt that he had an immense and lasting impact on his nation—and the world.